An Integrated IoT and Deep Learning Framework for Public Bus Safety and Passenger Intelligence in Sri Lanka

***Abstract*—Sri Lanka's urban public bus network serves millions of daily commuters, yet remains plagued by persistent safety hazards, erratic driver conduct, and a near-total absence of real-time operational intelligence. Passengers cannot reliably predict when their bus will arrive or how crowded it will be; operators have no scalable mechanism to monitor driver fatigue or traffic violations; and the vehicles themselves carry no dynamic awareness of load-dependent stopping requirements. This paper presents SafeTransit360, a unified, IoT-enabled safety and monitoring framework that addresses all three problem dimensions simultaneously.**

The system integrates four interdependent modules: (1) a real-time computer vision pipeline that detects driver fatigue, mobile phone use, and seat belt non-compliance using MediaPipe Face Mesh and a custom YOLOv8n model; (2) an edge-optimized ADAS module that identifies context-aware traffic rule violations through the fusion of instance segmentation (YOLOv8-seg), object detection (YOLOv8), and monocular depth estimation (MiDaS), all running on a Raspberry Pi 5 via ONNX Runtime; (3) a weight- and speed-aware safety module using distributed IoT sensing and a LightGBM regressor to recommend dynamic safe speeds in real time; and (4) a passenger intelligence system that fuses GPS telemetry with SLTB electronic ticketing data to predict bus arrival times and occupancy levels using LSTM-based deep learning.

Experimental evaluation demonstrates strong performance across all components. The seat belt detection model achieved 98.5% mAP50, while the driver state LSTM attained 94.5% classification accuracy across four behavioral states. The ADAS pipeline sustained 12–15 FPS on commodity edge hardware by reducing computational load by up to 75% through adaptive frame scheduling, and the Kalman-filtered lane tracker improved occlusion resilience by 84%. For passenger intelligence, the Bidirectional LSTM achieved MAE values of 2.29 and 2.18 passengers for boarding and alighting prediction ($R^2 = 0.87$ for alighting), while arrival time prediction reached an MAE of 102.99 seconds, roughly half the error of the ARIMA baseline. Collectively, these results confirm that SafeTransit360 delivers production-viable, real-time transit intelligence on low-cost hardware, establishing a deployable blueprint for public transport modernization in resource-constrained environments.

Keywords—Public Transport; Driver Monitoring; Context-Aware ADAS; YOLOv8; MiDaS; Edge Computing; LSTM; LightGBM; IoT; Raspberry Pi

I. INTRODUCTION

Millions of Sri Lankans rely on buses every single day. It's not a luxury; it's how people get to work, school, and hospitals. The Sri Lanka Transport Board (SLTB) and a network of private operators run the country's land transport backbone. But while the scale is impressive, the problems are equally large [1], [2].

Ask any commuter, and they'll tell you: you never really know when the bus is coming. It might be five minutes, it might be forty. And once it does show up, there's a decent chance it's already packed. Meanwhile, drivers push long hours with little monitoring for fatigue or risky behavior. Traffic violations go largely unchecked.

SafeTransit360 was built to tackle all of this in one go. It's a unified, IoT-enabled monitoring framework with four core modules: (1) Drowsiness Detection and Seat Belt Monitoring using MediaPipe and YOLOv8; (2) Context-Aware Rule Violation Monitoring using monocular vision; (3) a Weight and Speed-Based Safety System using LightGBM; and (4) a Real-Time Bus Tracking and Passenger Information System integrating GPS and ticketing data. This paper evaluates modules 1, 2, and 4 in depth. showing that you don't need a massive budget to build something genuinely effective.

II. LITERATURE REVIEW

A. Driver Drowsiness and Distraction Monitoring

Driver fatigue is one of the top contributors to public transport accidents and one of the hardest things to catch without disrupting the driver. That's why computer vision has become the go-to approach. Tools like MediaPipe extract subtle facial cues, Eye Aspect Ratio (EAR), and Mouth Aspect Ratio (MAR), in real time. Paired with an LSTM network, these geometric features yield a system that doesn't just detect a single drowsy moment but tracks how the driver's state evolves over time [3]. That temporal awareness is what separates a nuisance false alarm from a genuinely useful alert.

B. Advanced Driver Assistance Systems (ADAS)

High-end ADAS setups typically lean on LiDAR or stereo cameras. accurate, yes, but unaffordable for Sri Lanka's bus fleet. Monocular vision is the realistic alternative. Models like MiDaS generate useful relative depth maps from a single camera. Combined with instance segmentation from YOLOv8-seg for lane detection, you get a capable perception system at a fraction of the cost [4]. The real challenge is making it run on constrained edge hardware in real time. which is where conditional execution and ONNX Runtime optimization come in [5].

C. Bus Tracking and Prediction Models

Automatic Vehicle Location (AVL) systems can tell you where a bus is right now, but not when it will arrive or how crowded it will be [6]. LSTM-based deep learning models have shown strong results for both arrival time and passenger count prediction [7]–[10]. The key gap in Sri Lanka's context is the absence of smart card infrastructure. What does exist, however, is GPS data and electronic ticketing records, and it turns out that's enough to build something genuinely useful.

III. METHODOLOGY

A. Drowsiness Detection and Seat Belt Monitoring Pipeline

The driver monitoring module runs continuously on an edge device connected to a dashboard camera. MediaPipe Face Mesh extracts 468 3D facial landmarks every frame. Head pose, pitch, and yaw are then estimated using OpenCV's solvePnP algorithm.

1) Temporal State Classification (LSTM)

Extracted spatial features (EAR, MAR, pitch, yaw) are buffered into rolling 10-frame windows and fed into an LSTM network trained on the IBUG 300-W dataset. The network outputs one of four states: Alert, Drowsy, Yawning, or Head Turned. Ten frames rather than one because drowsiness is a gradual slide; catching the trend is more meaningful than flagging a single blurry eye.

2) Seat Belt and Phone Detection (YOLOv8)

A custom-trained YOLOv8n model handles seatbelt classification ('seatbelt' or 'no-seatbelt'), while a standard COCO-trained model picks up phone usage. YOLO processes every 8th frame with decay timers keeping bounding boxes alive between runs, delivering a real-time feel without burning through compute on every frame.

B. Context-Aware Rule Violation Monitoring Pipeline

This module monitors lane discipline, following distance, and wrong-side driving from a single forward-facing camera on a Raspberry Pi 4. No LiDAR. No radar. Just smart software.

1) Multi-Model Perception Fusion

Three models operate in parallel. The lane segmentation model (YOLOv8-seg) identifies lane boundaries. The object detection model (YOLOv8) tracks surrounding vehicles. The depth estimation model (MiDaS) converts bounding boxes into proximity estimates. Every frame, these outputs are fused into a single scene representation that the rule engine evaluates for violations, a clean separation of 'what' (perception) from 'so what' (rules).

2) Kalman-Filtered Lane Memory Tracker

Raw segmentation masks are inherently noisy. The system extracts a clean centerline by computing the median x-coordinate row by row through the mask, then applies a moving-average smoothing pass. Segments shorter than 20% of frame height are discarded to eliminate zebra crossings and worn road markings. Road curvature is encoded via the quadratic coefficient a in $x = ay^2 + by + c$, classifying road structure as STRAIGHT, LEFT_CURVE, RIGHT_CURVE, or S_CURVE, allowing lane-departure thresholds to be relaxed on curves, cutting false positives.

3) Context-Aware Adaptive Processing

Driving conditions are classified into five levels (MINIMAL to CRITICAL) based on speed and object proximity, adjusting frame processing frequency and active model set accordingly. The top 40% of each frame is cropped to eliminate sky and reduce unnecessary computation. A timed override forces full processing at regular intervals so nothing safety-critical slips through the optimization logic.

C. Bus Tracking Data Collection and Preprocessing

The dataset draws from SLTB's electronic ticketing system, boarding and alighting records with timestamps across multiple months on Colombo routes, with Route 177 as the primary test case. Trips are segmented using a 45-minute time-gap threshold. Derived features include time of day, day type, holiday flags, and peak hour indicators (7–9 AM, 5–7 PM) , simple attributes that turn out to be surprisingly predictive.

D. Arrival Time and Occupancy Prediction Models

Arrival time is predicted by an LSTM model taking sequences of four consecutive stops as input, each encoded with distance, hour, minute, and an 8-dimensional learned stop embedding. The architecture uses a 64-unit LSTM layer with L2 regularization, a 32-unit dense layer, and dropout (0.4), enough regularization to generalize beyond Route 177's specific patterns.

Passenger flow gets a beefier architecture: a three-layer Bidirectional LSTM (128→64→32 units) processing five-stop sequences enriched with lagged passenger counts and rolling averages. Bidirectional because passenger patterns have both forward- and backward-looking dependencies, peak hour history, and what happened at the last three stops both matter.

E. Weight and Speed-Based Safety System

A heavier bus needs more stopping distance, obvious, yet most buses don't account for it dynamically. An ESP32 microcontroller collects passenger count via dual IR sensors and total vehicle weight via four S-Beam load cells. That data travels to a Raspberry Pi over BLE (avg. 45 ms latency), where it fuses with NEO-6M GPS telemetry and publishes over MQTT to a LightGBM model that outputs a recommended safe speed. The driver sees Green/Yellow/Red LEDs, a buzzer, and an OLED display, real-time, intuitive, and hard to ignore.

IV. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

A. Drowsiness and Seat Belt Detection Performance

The YOLOv8 seatbelt model was tested on 696 images. TABLE I show the results, strong across the board. Near-perfect recall on the 'seatbelt worn' class (0.997) is exactly what you want when missing a violation carries real safety consequences.

TABLE I. YOLOv8 Seat Belt Detection Validation Metrics

Class	Images	Instances	Precision	Recall	mAP50
All	696	702	0.966	0.964	0.985
Seatbelt	538	543	0.966	0.997	0.989
No-Seatbelt	158	159	0.967	0.931	0.980

The temporal LSTM model achieved 94.5% overall accuracy across four driver states after 30 epochs with early stopping.

B. Context-Aware Rule Violation Performance

The multi-model pipeline was benchmarked on a Raspberry Pi 5 (8 GB RAM). TABLE II shows the adaptive processing efficiency gains. The Kalman-filtered lane tracker delivered an 84% improvement in boundary awareness during partial occlusions, a meaningful gain for real-world conditions where lane markings get worn or wet.

TABLE II. Adaptive Processing Efficiency Gains

Speed Profile	Frame Gap	Effective FPS	Compute Savings
Stationary	15	~25 FPS	75%–85%
Medium	8	~18 FPS	50%–60%
High (≥40 km/h)	2	~10 FPS	65%–70%

TABLE III. Road Line Detection Model Performance

Model	Box mAP50	Box mAP50-95	Mask mAP50	Mask mAP50-95
YOLOv8-seg	60.84%	42.72%	58.13%	33.26%

TABLE IV. Road Object Detection Model Performance

Model	mAP50	mAP50-95
YOLOv8	56.4%	46.8%

C. Arrival Time Prediction Performance

The LSTM arrival time model was evaluated on 20% of the Route 177 dataset. As shown in TABLE V, it achieved an MAE of 102.99 seconds (≈1.7 minutes), cutting the error roughly in half compared to the ARIMA baseline (≈2.8 minutes). Peak hours (7–9 AM) showed slightly higher deviation, unsurprisingly given how unpredictably Colombo morning traffic behaves.

TABLE V. Arrival Time Prediction Model Comparison

Model	MAE (s)	RMSE (s)	R^2
LSTM (Proposed)	102.99	134.11	0.127
XGBoost	207.64	426.34	0.107
LightGBM	74.90	102.40	0.096

D. Occupancy Prediction Performance

TABLE VI presents passenger flow results. The Bidirectional LSTM consistently outperforms both baselines. The alighting R^2 of 0.87 is the standout, with the net passenger change at R^2 = 0.81 right behind it. These aren't just academic metrics; they translate to commuters having reliable occupancy forecasts before the bus even arrives at their stop.

TABLE VI. Passenger Flow Prediction Model Performance

Target	Metric	Bi-LSTM	XGBoost	LightGBM
Boarding	MAE	2.29	3.21	3.18
	R^2	0.46	0.298	0.30
Alighting	MAE	2.18	2.85	2.79
	R^2	0.87	0.65	0.56
Net Change	MAE	3.29	4.02	3.98
	R^2	0.81	0.46	0.33

E. Weight and Speed-Based Safety System

The LightGBM safe speed regressor achieved R^2 = 0.887, MAE = 1.94 km/h, and RMSE = 2.57 km/h, explaining ≈89% of variance in safe speed requirements. BLE latency averaged 45 ms, and MQTT round-trip was ≈120 ms. The four-point load cell setup achieved 96% weight measurement accuracy, a 22% improvement over single-point sensing, particularly important during cornering when weight distribution shifts.

F. Discussion

Taken together, these results tell a clear story: SafeTransit360 works, not in a lab demo way, but in the sense that every component delivers measurable, practically useful performance on real data and real hardware.

The 98.5% mAP50 seatbelt detector, combined with the 10-frame LSTM drowsiness tracker, gives operators a compliance monitoring layer that was simply absent before. The context-aware ADAS module proves that instance segmentation and depth estimation can run on a Raspberry Pi, you just have to be smart about when. For passengers, a 1.7-minute arrival MAE is transformative in a system where current predictability is essentially zero. The decoupled ESP32–Raspberry Pi architecture validates that high-fidelity IoT sensing and vision model performance can coexist and scale across an entire fleet.

V. CONCLUSION

SafeTransit360 demonstrates what becomes possible when public transport problems are addressed as an integrated system rather than isolated silos. Driver safety, traffic monitoring, and passenger forecasting are deeply connected, and a unified framework makes each component stronger.

The key contributions are concrete: a 98.5%-accurate driver compliance monitor; a 12–15 FPS context-aware violation system on sub-$100 hardware; and a transit forecasting engine that predicts arrivals within 1.7 minutes and passenger loads within 2.2 passengers on average. Future work will focus on OBD-II integration for direct speed validation, expansion to private bus networks, and federated learning for privacy-preserving fleet-wide model improvement. The foundation is solid — and the next steps are clear.

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